DEFENCE

INDO-US: CIRCLING THE WAGONS

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A FRIEND IN DELHI
Rajnath Singh with US defense secretary Lloyd Austin on June 5

US secretary of defense Lloyd James Austin landed in New Delhi barely two weeks before Prime Minister Narendra Modi's official visit to Washington from June 21. According to a US department of defense statement, Austin is in India "to reinforce major defence partnership and advance cooperation in critical domains" between the strategic partners. During his meeting with defence minister Rajnath Singh, a road map for defence industrial cooperation with the goal of fast-tracking technology transfer and co-production was agreed upon.

"This initiative aims to change the paradigm for cooperation between the US and Indian defence sectors, including specific proposals that could provide India access to cutting-edge technologies and support India's defence modernisation plans," the DoD statement said, adding that both Austin and Rajnath were committed to supporting India's leading role as a security provider in the Indo-Pacific. They discussed new opportunities to strengthen information-sharing and increase maritime cooperation.

Austin's visit has the mega project of co-producing fighter jet engines as its immediate takeaway, with US firm General Electric and India's public sector undertaking Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) likely to ink a deal for joint production of GE F414 turbofan engines in India. With New Delhi looking to manufacture jet engines through technology transfer to power its fighter aircraft, the GE F414 pact might be announced during the Modi-Biden meeting later in the month. The GE F414 engine is selected for use in the Medium Weight Fighter (MWF) Tejas-Mk2, the fifth-generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) and the twin-engine deck-based fighter (TEDBF). All three aircraft are under development.

INDIA ASKED THE US TO SIMPLIFY THE PROCESS OF DEFENCE SALES AND TRANSFER OF TECHNOLOGY

The US has been supplying multiple platforms to India, but has never shared critical technology like jet engines, despite designating India as a "major defence partner" in 2016. However, the dynamics of the US-India defence ties have changed, especially in the backdrop of the Ukraine conflict. According to South Block mandarins, Washington believes that until it helps reduce India's dependence on Russian military platforms (nearly 70 per cent of Indian military's hardware is of Russian origin), New Delhi will continue to maintain a strategic balance between Moscow and the West. India's measured stand on the Ukraine conflict is testimony to that fact.

India-US strategic ties have received an immense fillip due to the growing aggression of the Chinese military not only along the Line of Actual Control, but also in the South China Sea—"bullying and coercion" by China, as Austin put it. The US has been sharing real-time intelligence with India on Chinese troop manoeuvres during and after the face-off with China on the LAC.

Frank O'Donnell, a non-resident fellow at the Washington-based Stimson Center, tells INDIA TODAY that discussions during Austin's visit signal serious intent to break down barriers to closer US-India defence cooperation. Indeed, India asked the US to simplify the process of sale of military hardware and transfer of critical defence technology.

Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), former co-chair, India-US DTTI (Defence Technology and Trade Initiative) task force, says India needs to be pragmatic about expectations. "As we proceed deeper in forging this relationship, the number of stakeholders and dimensions of cooperation will increase," he says. ■